

The Legacy Heritage Innovation Project



SUPPORTING JEWISH EDUCATIONAL CHANGE AND SYNAGOGUE TRANSFORMATION

Letter of Intent for Legacy Heritage Innovation Project: Congregational Education Grant

Before proceeding, please read carefully the “Overview of the Legacy Heritage Innovation Project.” All Letters of Intent must be completed according to the format below and sent by email to Rabbi Marc Margolius (marcm@lhfl.net), **by 3:00 p.m. Wednesday, December 2, 2009**. Contact Rabbi Margolius at (212) 578-8190, ext. 106 or at marcm@lhfl.net with any questions. Applicants will be notified by **Thursday, January 7, 2010** as to whether they are invited to submit a full proposal for Legacy Heritage Innovation Project grant.

To complete the Letter of Intent, please type only in the gray boxes, using no less than 11 point font, and observing limitations on length.

Note the following suggestions to consider in preparing your Letter of Intent:

Please be as concise and specific as you can as to how you propose to:

- ***Link your project to the synagogue’s required children’s educational program (if any).***
- ***Restructure adult and children’s education*** to embed it in rhythm of Jewish living, as opposed to augmenting a program that takes place during the week or Sundays.
- ***Actively engage participants***, as opposed to creating and publicizing a new program – e.g. “if we build it better, they will come.” For example, what is the mechanism by which parents will be engaged on an ongoing basis? Will there be an expectation or requirement to which they will subscribe?
- ***Build upon your congregation’s current strengths and achievements***
- ***Stress incremental approaches with attainable objectives*** (“low hanging fruit”).

Please avoid:

- ***Wish lists*** of “additive” and/or disconnected programming ideas; instead, explain how your approach would be integrated and systemic – see examples on our website, http://www.legacyheritage.org/ip_funds.html.
- ***“Hopeful” language*** (“we hope to/we imagine/we envision”), unless supported by tangible evidence that you will succeed at what you propose. If possible, cite support from focus groups, surveys, phone calls, evidence of past successes which are directly linked to proposal. We’re wary about the “if you build it they will come” approach to programming.
- ***Generalities or hyperbolic descriptions*** of your programming or congregation.
- ***Approaches which are favored by one or more professionals but which do not yet enjoy broader support from other staff and lay leadership.***



Name of congregation: Shir Hadash Reconstructionist Synagogue

Address: 3340 Dundee Road, Suite 2N4, Northbrook, IL 60062

Telephone: (847) 498-8218

Fax: (847) 291-8930

Website: www.shir-hadash.org

Denomination (Orthodox, Conservative, Reform, Reconstructionist, Other/non-Denominational): Reconstructionist

of member units (households) 190

of children (k-7) enrolled in congregational school (if any): 170

of children enrolled in day school (K-7):

Dates and hours that congregational school (if any) meets: Sunday Mornings (09:15 - 12:25)

Rabbi (name/e-mail): Rabbi Eitan Weiner-Kaplow / rabbi@shir-hadash.org

Educational Director (name/email): Emily Ascher / eddirector@shir-hadash.org

President (name/email): Neil Charak / charak@mac.com

Proposed title of project: Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey”

Dollar amount requested for funding: \$30,000

Names and title(s) or role(s) of each person involved or consulted in preparing this Letter of Inquiry: Lauren Tashma (Board), Dawn Allen (Education Committee Chair), Deborah Newberger (Former President), Neil Charak (President), Jeffrey Wallk (Board), Steve Fisher (Education Committee), Carol Mostow (Youth Director), Emily Ascher (Education Director), Rabbi Eitan Weiner-Kaplow

Contact person in relation to this Letter of Intent (name, phone, email):
(Emily Ascher, (847) 498-8218, eddirector@shir-hadash.org)

**READINESS/CAPACITY:**

Indicate (one-two pages, double-spaced maximum) as specifically as possible your congregation's readiness and capacity for implementing your proposal by describing: (1) the degree and nature of professional and lay involvement in planning this proposal, and (2) specific, concrete evidence of "buy-in" from lay leaders and congregants (e.g., surveys or focus groups involving potential participants, experience with piloting the approach you propose, or other specific evidence of support among congregants).

Shir Hadash Reconstructionist Synagogue is a small vibrant community which has built a legacy for innovative approaches towards celebrating Judaism. Our mission is to inspire meaningful and contemporary Jewish living. This single most important thing we can offer our membership is a reason to participate (not simply belong). This proposal will allow us to further our mission and help us build a stronger sense of community for all of our members and their families through participation in a new Shabbat program where they can create their own personal journeys in renewal, expanded learning, and Tikkun Olam.

As Reconstructionists, we view Judaism as more than a religion; it is a way of life to be enjoyed and celebrated in a caring community. In a fast paced and hi-tech world, Shir Hadash is about building lasting relationships with friends, who become an extended part of our congregational family. Together, we share the radiance of festivals, creating meaning through mitzvahs, and sharing the joyous blessings of life and growth.

Consistent with our values, our religious school has demonstrated a strong "grass roots movement" in connection with the celebration of Shabbat. Parents, teachers and students have organized grade specific pot luck Shabbat dinners which provide an opportunity to share different family's traditions. Other Shabbat dinners feature a professional Jewish story teller who has regaled the children with Jewish folk tales. Our Gan Yeladim students participated in a Shabbat "under nighter" during which all of the kids arrive in pajamas, share a Shabbat meal and then participate in a song fest with our Rabbi. In addition to these more informal programs, our youth group, SHY ("Shir Hadash Youth"), has a strong program which reaches out to fourth graders through high school age kids. SHY offers monthly opportunities for our kids to



participate in social programming mitzvah and social action projects, Shabbat social activities, and creative educational programs. Our religious school includes not only a study of Hebrew and Judaica, but also blends folkways into contemporary programs that bring renewed emphasis on teaching our children about Jewish living. Our students learn about Israeli dance, Jewish cooking and Jewish fine arts. Our school program also includes a “family education” component where families are invited into our school to participate in special programming with the students. For example, our fourth graders are going to participate in a “turn about” session in December, in which they assume the role of teachers and teach their parents what they have learned about Israel, including teaching them how to sing Hatikva and explaining to their parents the history of the birth of Israel through a creative use of drama.

The success of our current programming rests in large part on the dedication and enthusiasm of our Rabbi (Eitan Weiner-Kaplow), our Education Director (Emily Ascher) and our Youth Director (Carole Mostow). Together, they have built a strong foundation for our students and their families. But, we need to reach beyond the families with students as this only represents half of our members. We want to expand our innovative programming to bring inclusivity to our entire membership by expanding our Shabbat-related programs to further cement the many ties that exist between the families in our school. All three of our professionals have demonstrated a strong willingness to take our current programming to the next level. So, we recently conducted focus groups sessions to explore ideas that our members would like to see in our programming. We brought together congregants representing all aspects of our congregation, including young parents, members with children in our school and empty nesters. The wealth of ideas that were harvested from those focus groups touched on various themes such as ways to build more internal community as well as to establish more ties to the external community, ways to expand our families’ understanding of the richness of Judaism through intergenerational exchanges, and ways to explore Shabbat through the arts.



We confirmed a high correlation of interest amongst our members to support the expansion of our Shabbat programs to promote a greater sense of community.

PROPOSAL:

Describe (four-five pages maximum, double-spaced) your proposal to integrate children's, family, and adult learning consistently into the context of home and/or communal Shabbat and holiday celebration. In particular, describe how your approach would (1) significantly intensify parental and children's engagement in Jewish living and learning on Shabbat and holidays, (2) link parents and children with other aspects of the congregational community (e.g. adult learners, "empty-nester" members, teens, etc.), (3) integrate different aspects of Jewish life (e.g. connecting ritual life, education, *gemilut hasadim*, *tikkun olam*, etc.), (4) promote greater collaboration among congregational staff and lay leadership, and (5) align the approach with the congregation's core vision.

The goal of our request is to fund a sustainable program with outside assistance so we can formalize our programs, develop our staff, and provide new skills for volunteer resources to expand the work we do now and improve the value we deliver to the community. We have created a family mitzvah program, which builds upon the foundational work that we've established through our education program. In order to expand the reach of this program to all of our members and their families, we need to build a more cohesive program of activities and processes that we can institutionalize to ensure that we involve all of our members, their families and build external relationships with our local communities.

We plan to accomplish this by expanding upon the themes in our current programming to launch a true family Havurot program, tentatively titled (Shalom Shabbat – "A Family Journey"). This program will build on our past successes in family programming and (for the first time) make a concerted effort to reach out beyond the families directly involved in our educational community. Our focus groups were uniformly enthusiastic about moving in this direction and provided a wealth of ideas for possible activities in which the Havurot would engage. A common thread of ideas from our focus groups involved the following concepts:

- Ways to make Judaism accessible to all
- Ways to promote inter-generational learning



- Ways to create shared experiences away from our temple
- Ways to create meaningful new experiences
- Ways to engage students outside of our temple in the learning experience

The focus groups suggested ideas which the Havurot could sponsor: learning more about people with various special needs and then creating a unique Shabbat experience for them, creating artwork that captured the weekly Torah portion, creating a Shabbat blog that acts as a vehicle for sharing the Havurot's Shabbat experiences as well as a way to engage people who may not be able to join our services live in a "virtual Shabbat" experience that reconnects them to our community. Many of the proposed activities also emphasized bringing in views and teachings from outside of our community to broaden the community's world view of Judaism. Suggestions for speakers included outside educators, artists, Israeli soldiers, authors and musicians.

The Shalom Shabbat – "A Family Journey" program will expand family participation and build a more enriching experience in Jewish learning by providing an engaging vehicle for parents, children, grandparents and empty nesters to come together in a variety of activities designed to spark discussion, learn new things and share in the folkways of our people. Here are just a few of the ideas (captured from our focus groups) which we plan on pursuing:

- Create a Shabbat service to engage the elder members of the Jewish community
- Create a music festival based on "kasha-type" music (new age jazz with a Jewish influence)
- Develop a program to provide care for seniors and assist with daily issues
- Help out economically challenged members with home repairs
- Establish an online video library of classes to reach our "virtual" students



- Formalize a program where the generations can share and capture their stories which can be preserved and passed on to current and future members
- Setup an area-wide food competition amongst members from surrounding congregations (where the food and proceeds go to families in need)

The Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program will also provide a way to bridge the gap between those families involved in the religious school and other members of our congregation. While half of our congregation is young families with children who attend our school, the remaining half of congregants are completely untouched by our outreach programs emanating from our school. Our Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program will encourage family Havurot to reach out to the “other half” of members, who are not affiliated with the school (as they may be older, empty nesters, or have children who have been bar/bat mitzvah’d) to participate in these engaging new activities to create an ongoing Jewish learning experience through a participatory celebration of Shabbat.

Our religious school already incorporates a strong dedication to the concept of Tikkun Olam amongst our students. We are now ready to expand the programs to include families of the students and the families who have not participated as extensively. For example, each fall our students and their families gather for Yom Tikkun Olam, our day to fan out across the community to make the world a better place. This year families worked on a number of projects, including: working at a local center servicing adults with disabilities, collecting items needed by a local animal shelter and gathering to bake dog biscuits, collecting childrens’ books and organizing them for donation to inner-city schools in need of books, visiting senior citizens as a local nursing home, and clearing brush at a community nature preserve. The theme of repairing the world will be integral to the program as well. Each family Havurot will be encouraged to sponsor a cause in the community which the families will work to support. At



least once each quarter, families will gather and devote time to that cause, whether it is working in a soup kitchen, organizing a coat drive, or volunteering at a local nursing home.

Our plans for expanding our programming were in the planning well before the current economic challenges impacted both our members and our local communities. As we do not have a building, the need for renewing and expanding the sense of community has never been stronger or more necessary. The infusion of funding will provide necessary training, guidance and bring formality to help us institutionalize this program and build sustainable model for delivering value to all of our families and our surrounding community.

Our goal is to institutionalize and expand our program, by bringing in outside expertise to provide formal programs, training for staff, and develop new skills amongst the volunteers who will help us drive our program forward. The Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program will provide a more expansive opportunity for our congregational staff to drive themes and projects through a broader network of lay leaders. The Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program will also create new leadership opportunities for the lay leaders to work directly with our congregational staff to create programming.

Our core mission (“To inspire meaningful and contemporary Jewish living”) is brought to fruition by the Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program. The programming that we propose will open many doors for families to participate and create their own personal journeys to learn about contemporary Jewish living through our celebratory approach for Shabbat. The goal for our Shabbat programs has always been to promote inclusivity and participation. However, the Shalom Shabbat – “A Family Journey” program will help us realize our vision for becoming a living example of a Reconstructionist Jewish community, based upon Jewish values (which are embodied in [our mission](#) and in [our school](#)), folkways and traditions.



**ANTICIPATED IMPACT:**

Describe (one page, double-spaced, maximum) how your proposal would have a transformational impact upon participants, as opposed to simply increasing the extent of participation in programming.

Currently, we have some incredible and innovative family programming, but it resides within the boundaries of our religious school. We need to expand this programming to integrate all our different “lifestage” members. While we have in the past opened programming such as our Yom Tikkun Olam program to other members in the congregation, we have not been able to significantly break down the barriers which exist between school families and the remainder of the congregation. It is imperative, however, that we find a way to bridge the gap between these two parts of our congregation: those who participate in school related programs and the students and their families who have graduated and moved on. Our goal is integrate current students and their families into a new family Havurot program and encourage ongoing family participation even after the student has graduated from our school program. This transitional program will not only allow us to touch the lives of empty nesters and members without children, but will also help us to maintain a connection with all families and to bring a more meaningful relationship between families and their sense of Judaism.



BUDGET ESTIMATE: With as much specificity as you can at this point, provide a budget estimate for your proposal using the categories below. Note that **grant funds are not intended to defray current synagogue operational expenses, subsidize existing programs, or hire temporary personnel** unless the congregation provides a plan to sustain the position upon the grant's termination. **Preference is afforded to budgets favoring "sustainable" resources** (staff and lay leadership training, reusable materials, etc.), as opposed to one-time expenses (guest speakers, scholarships/subsidies, etc.)

Process (NOTE: this must equal <u>at least one-third</u> of total grant expenditures; examples are professional consulting/coaching in organizational change for congregational leadership and/or staff, board retreats, etc.)	
Professional coaching	\$4000
Leadership training	\$3500
3rd Party trainer	\$5500
Program (Examples: reusable materials and supplies, guest instructors/speakers to build congregational capacity, and PR/marketing (<u>not</u> food or refreshments).	
Program development framework	\$5000
Training Materials (train the trainer)	\$4600
Communication materials	\$2400
Personnel (Examples: participation in educational training, and/or stipends or supplemental compensation for staff members who undergo training or assume additional responsibilities as a result of the funded initiative.)	
Education Director (extending role to institutionalize the program)	\$5000
Evaluation (10% of total budget)	\$3,000
Congregational matching funds	\$2,000
Transportation cost for sending rabbi and lead educator to LHIP seminar June 7-9, 2010 (both <u>must</u> attend)	\$500
TOTAL EXPENDITURES	\$35,500